

Social Media Micro-Targeting and Youth Voter Turnout: An Empirical Field Experiment

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Abstract: This study investigates whether micro-targeted digital get-out-the-vote (GOTV) campaigns on social media increase voter participation among young adults. Using a randomized field experiment across 12 municipal districts during the 2024 elections, we measure the differential impact of non-partisan civic reminders versus issue-congruent targeted advertisements.

1. Research Question

Research Question: To what extent do algorithmic micro-targeted GOTV advertisements on social media platforms increase verified voter turnout among young citizens (aged 18–24) compared to non-targeted civic broadcasting?

2. Empirical Methodology & Data Collection

Empirical Methodology & Data Collection: A randomized controlled field experiment was conducted across 12 municipal electoral districts (N = 45,000 registered voters aged 18–24). Participants were assigned to three groups: Control (no digital ads, n = 15,000), Treatment A (generic non-partisan civic GOTV ads, n = 15,000), and Treatment B (issue-congruent micro-targeted GOTV ads based on online behavior metrics, n = 15,000). Official municipal voting records were matched post-election with anonymized participant IDs to verify actual ballot casting.

Table 1: Empirical Findings Summary

Experimental Group	Sample Size (N)	Verified Turnout (%)	Treatment Effect (pp)	p-value
Control Group (No Ads)	15,000	28.4%	Baseline	—
Treatment A (Generic GOTV)	15,000	31.1%	+2.7%	< 0.05
Treatment B (Micro-Targeted)	15,000	35.8%	+7.4%	< 0.001

3. Discussion & Implications

Discussion & Conclusion: The empirical evidence indicates a statistically significant increase in verified youth turnout resulting from micro-targeted GOTV ads (+7.4 percentage points over control). While generic civic reminders yield modest gains (+2.7 pp), tailored messaging directly addresses topic saliency and lowers information barriers for first-time voters. However, concerns regarding algorithmic transparency and political ad tracking remain critical considerations for election integrity.